As a young R&AW operative, Krishna remembered the celebrations on the streets of Calcutta when Bangladesh achieved its independence. Although the move by India was a sort of political adventurism on the part of the Indira Gandhi government, the R&AW did not disappoint the prime minister. India's external spy agency announced its arrival in the world of shadows by liberating a new country with the help of the army.

Krishna had started his operations from a safe house in Calcutta in April 1970 under the protective cover of a bogus export-import company. 'I thought we were invincible but the bungling by diplomats in the following years made us vulnerable. And there was the possibility that our neighbours could unite against us,' he told me.

Alarmed, Krishna flew to Delhi in December 1975 to meet his boss R.N. Kao at his residence. The R&AW chief was worried about what he saw as Pakistan and China moving quietly to penetrate the Bangladeshi government and neutralise whatever little influence India still enjoyed in a certain section of the administration.

'There had to be coordinated action before Pakistan's Inter Service intelligence (ISI) led by Lt General Ghulam Jilani Khan created new uncertainties in Bangladesh. Above all, there was fear that Pakistan may soon enter every sphere of Bangladeshi life and India would pay a heavy political price. Kao agreed there was a serious threat that no one in the spy agency could ignore/ Krishna recalled.

Within days, the R&AW had drafted a note analysing the threat from Pakistan and a plan to confront it effectively. 'A decision was taken to recruit more informers in the areas covering the entire Bangladeshi coast and land boundaries. To pick up solid